

An attempt at understanding dolphin language is being made — will people listen?

Since it was first published in 1979, Douglas Adams's **The Hitchhiker's** Guide to the Galaxy has seen generations of the philosophically minded expand on some of its **themes**. The **series** of books **is** comical, of course, as it **satirises ontology, metaphysics**, the **pomposity** of politicians, the **dreadful diatribes** of **bureaucrats**. But in all the fun of **puns**, Adams **often stumbled** into, **perhaps** knowingly, **profound** questions. The most popular of these is the Babel Fish argument — based on a creature that, by **eliminating** all boundaries to **interspecies** communication across the galaxy, caused the most dreadful wars of all. And then there's the **enigma** of dolphins. As the Earth is about to be destroyed in the first book, they leave the planet, leaving behind a one-line message: "So long, and thanks for all the fish." Now, as AI models threaten and promise to make the fears and **fortunes** of sci-fi worlds a reality, Adams's questions might just be answered.

This year, **the Coller-Dolittle Prize** — given for research into two-way inter-species communication — **was** awarded to the Sarasota Dolphin Research Program. It has used **non-invasive** methodologies to study the various **vocalisations** and body language of bottlenose dolphins for about 40 years. This data can be used to train AI models that can potentially **uncover** the layers of meaning in non-human language.



The **dolphins** in Hitchhiker's **were** smarter than human beings. And perhaps, for a given definition of intelligence, life can **imitate** art. For a long time, human beings have ignored the **personhood** of intelligent animals. Elephants, higher **primates**, dolphins and whales — there are several species that have language and heritage, that laugh and cry and **grieve**, have a sense of family, self and community. Perhaps AI can translate their realities in a way humans can understand them, and learn from them. But then, **given** that people are so **adept at** treating people as things, what chance does a dolphin have?

[Practice Exercise]

- Red/blue coloring of words in the sentence indicates subject verb relationship; where 'red' denotes 'subject' and 'blue' denotes 'verb'.

Vocabulary

1. **Hitchhiker** (noun) – someone who travels by getting free rides in someone else's vehicle मुफ्त यात्रा करने वाला
2. **Theme** (noun) – subject, topic, idea, concept, motif विषय
3. **Satirise** (verb) – mock, ridicule, lampoon, parody, criticize व्यंग्य करना
4. **Ontology** (noun) – The branch of metaphysics dealing with the nature of being.
5. **Metaphysic** (noun) – the branch of philosophy that deals with the first principles of things, including abstract concepts such as being, knowing, identity, time, and space.
6. **Pomposity** (noun) – arrogance, haughtiness, boastfulness, grandiosity, self-importance घमंड
7. **Dreadful** (adjective) – terrible, awful, horrifying, frightening, appalling भयानक
8. **Diatribes** (noun) – tirade, rant, denunciation, harangue, criticism कटु आलोचना
9. **Bureaucrat** (noun) – official, administrator, civil servant, functionary, government officer नौकरशाह
10. **Pun** (noun) – wordplay, double meaning, quibble, play on words, joke शब्दों का खेल
11. **Often** (adverb) – frequently, regularly, repeatedly, commonly, usually अक्सर
12. **Stumble** (verb) – falter, slip, trip, blunder, flounder ठोकर खाना / चूक जाना
13. **Perhaps** (adverb) – maybe, possibly, conceivably, perchance, it could be शायद
14. **Profound** (adjective) – deep, meaningful, thoughtful, insightful, intense गहरा / गंभीर
15. **Eliminate** (verb) – remove, eradicate, abolish, get rid of, extinguish हटाना / समाप्त करना
16. **Interspecies** (adjective) – cross-species, inter-animal, trans-species, multi-species, inter-organism प्रजातियों के बीच
17. **Enigma** (noun) – mystery, puzzle, riddle, conundrum, paradox रहस्य / पहेली
18. **Fortune** (noun) – fate, luck, destiny, prosperity, wealth भाग्य / संपत्ति
19. **Non-invasive** (adjective) – gentle, non-intrusive, external, harmless, non-interfering बिना शरीर में प्रवेश किए
20. **Vocalisation** (noun) – utterance, sound, expression, articulation, speech ध्वनि / स्वर
21. **Uncover** (verb) – reveal, expose, discover, disclose, detect उजागर करना

22. **Imitate** (verb) – copy, mimic, emulate,
replicate, mirror नकल करना

23. **Personhood** (noun) – individuality,
identity, selfhood, being, existence
व्यक्तित्व

24. **Primate** (noun) – ape, monkey,
chimpanzee, gorilla, lemur प्रमुख वानर

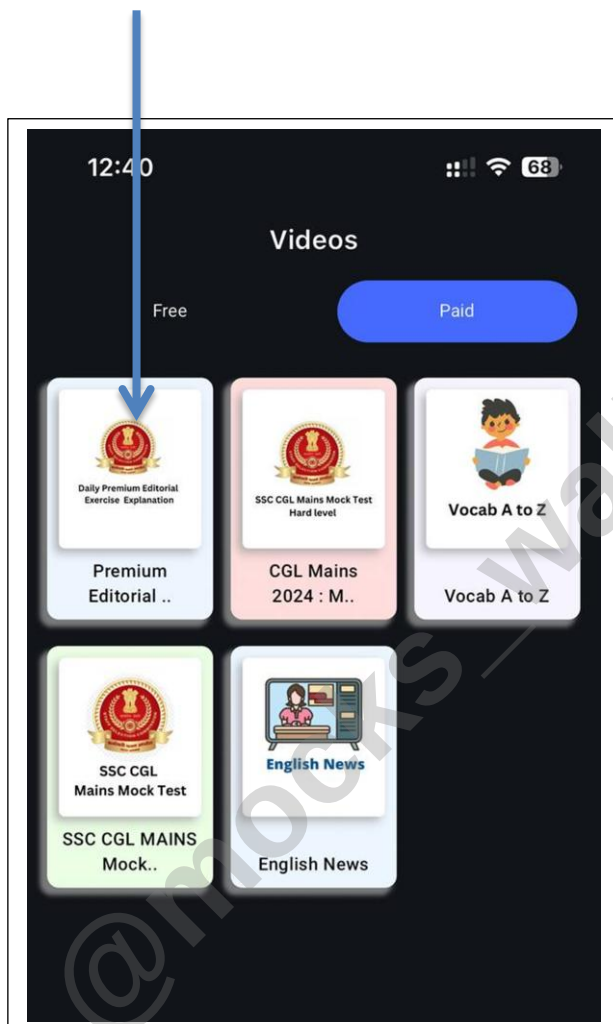
25. **Grieve** (verb) – mourn, lament, sorrow,
suffer, regret शोक मनाना

26. **Given** (preposition) – considering,
assuming, based on, in view of, taking into
account को देखते हुए

27. **Adept** (at) (adjective) – skilled, proficient,
expert, capable, talented कुशल

@mocks_wallah

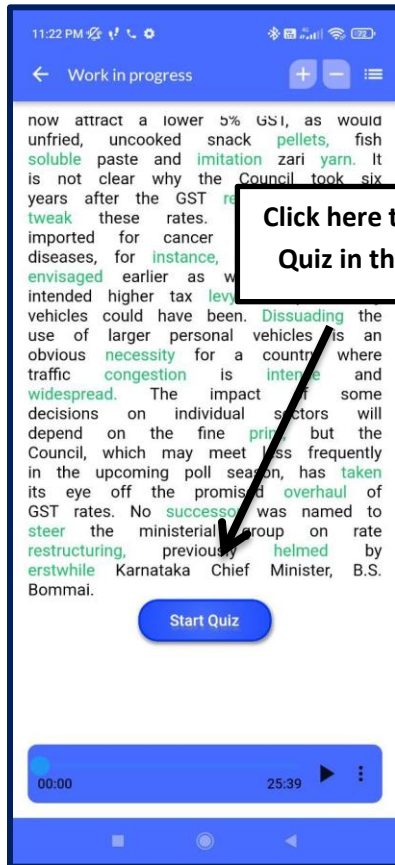
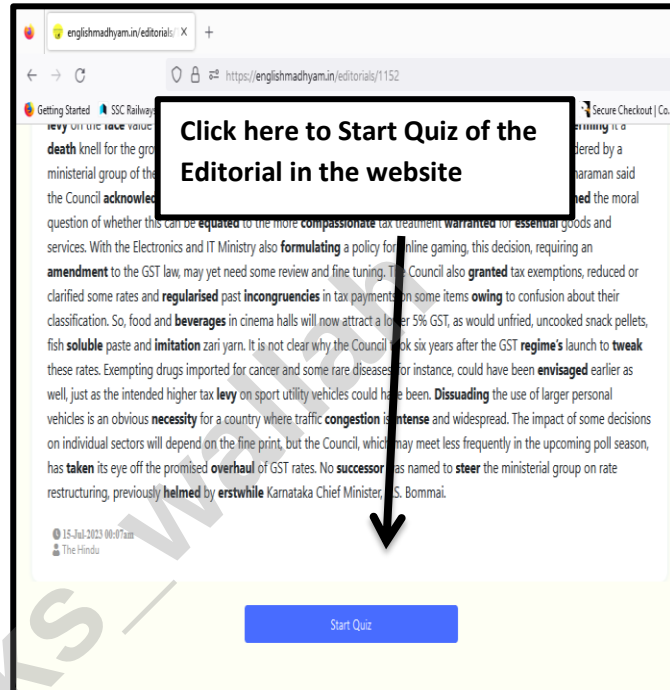
Video solution of Practice Exercise from this Editorial is exclusively available on App.



Summary of the Editorial

1. **Douglas Adams's Inspiration** – The editorial draws on *The Hitchhiker's Guide to the Galaxy* to reflect on the theme of interspecies communication.
2. **Satirical Yet Profound** – While comedic, the book poses deep philosophical questions about communication, intelligence, and existence.
3. **Babel Fish Analogy** – The concept of the Babel Fish, which enables perfect communication but causes conflict, is used to highlight complexities in understanding others.
4. **Dolphins in Fiction** – In Adams's story, dolphins are portrayed as more intelligent than humans, subtly questioning human supremacy.
5. **Sci-fi Turning Real** – The editorial suggests that the speculative ideas of sci-fi may be turning into reality through advances in AI.
6. **Award for Dolphin Research** – The Sarasota Dolphin Research Program won the Coller-Dolittle Prize for work on two-way communication with dolphins.
7. **Long-Term Study** – The program has spent 40 years observing bottlenose dolphins' vocalisations and body language using non-invasive methods.
8. **AI Application** – This large dataset is now being used to train AI to decode and possibly translate dolphin communication.
9. **Animal Intelligence** – Dolphins, like elephants and primates, show signs of intelligence such as emotion, community bonds, and communication.
10. **Ignored Personhood** – Human society has historically denied animals like dolphins recognition of their complex inner lives or personhood.
11. **Ethical Questions** – The editorial raises ethical concerns: even if humans can understand animals, will they listen or care?
12. **Human Cruelty** – It points out that humans often objectify even other humans, casting doubt on their ability to respect non-human minds.
13. **Hope in Technology** – There is a cautious optimism that AI might act as a bridge between species by translating non-human realities.
14. **Risk of Misuse** – However, there's a warning that even perfect translation may not lead to empathy or ethical behavior.
15. **Call for Empathy** – Ultimately, the piece questions not just the *ability* to communicate with dolphins, but the *willingness* of people to truly listen and act on it.

Practice Exercise: SSC Pattern Based

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